The Baton and the Race

A Lineage-Primary Analogy for Digital Preservation

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Purpose

This document provides an analogy to help archivists, technologists, and policy designers understand lineage-based preservation.

§1 — The Analogy

In an athletic relay race, the baton is not the point. The point is the unbroken continuity of the race itself — the handoff from one runner to the next, generation after generation.

The baton is merely the current physical carrier of that continuity.

Element

Analogue in preservation

The race

The lineage — the unbroken continuity of identity through time

The baton

The current physical instantiation (file, hard drive, ceramic media, stone tablet)

The runners

Successive generations of caretakers, archivists, or communities

The handoff

The lineage event — the documented act of transmission

The finish line

There is no fixed finish line. Preservation continues only while continuity is maintained.

§2 — What the Baton Is Not

The baton is not the identity of the race.

If the baton gets scratched, the race does not end.

If the baton is dropped but remains under continuous custody, the race continues.

If the baton is replaced mid-race with an identical baton, the race remains valid — provided the handoff is recorded and the lineage is clear.

If the baton is lost and a new one is introduced without a documented handoff, the race ends — not because the new baton is different, but because continuity was interrupted.

In lineage-primary terms:

The object is the carrier. The lineage is the identity.

§3 — What the Handoff Requires

A successful handoff requires four conditions — corresponding to the core predicates of 8PF.

tf0 (Trusted Foundational Zero) — the formally declared starting point of a lineage.

Predicate

In relay terms

Origin (O)

The race has a declared starting point (tf0). Everyone agrees where and when it began.

Inheritance (I)

The baton is passed directly from runner to runner. No silent swaps. No gaps in custody.

Descent (D)

Each runner accepts the baton as belonging to the same race they received.

Sanctioned (S)

Each runner has legitimate authority to carry the baton. No one seizes it by force or fraud.

If any predicate fails, the lineage breaks. The race ends — even if the baton is still moving.

Example — A Practical Handoff

A digital photograph originally stored on magnetic tape is transferred to a hard disk as part of a preservation migration.

The photograph's existence on tape is documented as the declared starting point (Origin).

The file is copied directly from tape to disk with no unrecorded substitutions (Inheritance).

The receiving system records the file as the same photograph previously held (Descent).

The transfer is performed and verified by an authorised custodian whose authority is recorded (Sanctioned).

This constitutes a valid lineage handoff.

The physical carrier has changed — but the race continues.

§4 — The Caring Gap

A relay race continues only as long as each generation chooses to pick up the baton and keep running.

No rulebook can force this.

No technology can guarantee it.

The caring gap occurs when a generation looks at the baton and asks:

“Why should I carry this?”

If they cannot answer, the race ends.

The baton may sit in a vault, perfectly preserved yet no longer actively interpreted — physically present but functionally silent.

§5 — What This Means for Technical Preservation

Building better batons — more durable media, longer bit-retention, higher density — is beneficial.

But a better baton does not guarantee a better race.

A technical preservation strategy that focuses only on the baton is incomplete. It must also address:

The lineage record — who declared inception? What transformations have occurred? Where is the provenance?

The handoff mechanism — how is custody transferred between generations? How are lineage events recorded and verified?

The caring gap — how does each generation renew its commitment to carrying the race forward?

These are not purely technical problems.

They are governance, cultural, and ethical problems.

Technology can support them — but it cannot replace them.

§6 — One-Sentence Summary

The object is the baton, not the race. Build better batons — but never confuse them for the race itself.

§7 — Caveat: The Race Can Restart

The analogy above describes a continuous race — one generation handing directly to the next.

But this is not the only possible future.

If the race ends — if the last runner drops the baton and no one picks it up — the baton may still remain.

If that baton carries enough information — not just data, but instructions — a future finder may recognise it for what it was.

The baton may communicate:

“This was a race. Here is where it began. Here is how it was carried. Here is what it meant. If you wish, you may start running again.”

In this scenario:

The original lineage is not restored to continuity.

A lineage with interrupted continuity cannot be reconstructed as an unbroken sequence — even if the original material survives intact.

But a new lineage can be founded, one that acknowledges its connection to the earlier one.

The finder becomes a new tf0, declaring a new inception.

The earlier baton becomes an ancestor, not a predecessor.

The new race is not the same race — but it is inspired by it, informed by it, and guided by the preserved record.

This is the function of deep interpretability layers and recovery pathways:

not to guarantee continuity, but to make restart possible.

A baton that carries only raw data is merely stored material.

A baton that carries the story of the race offers something rarer:

the possibility of beginning again.

§8 — Final One-Sentence Summary

The object is the baton, not the race. Build better batons — but also write on them what the race was for, so that if continuity is interrupted, someone may someday choose to begin again.